

Changes in Italian Fashion Between 1929 and 1955

To what extent can it be said that Italian women's fashion changed between 1929 and 1955?

Introduction to Italian Culture

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Introduction

Between the first of September 1939 and the second of September 1945, one of the most recognized and studied historical facts in the world took place, a military conflict known as The Second World War. In it, the major powers of the moment, allied in two groups, were involved in endless battles that led to the ruin of hundreds of territories and the division of countries. The two groups in conflict were the Axis, formed by Japan, Italy and Germany, and the Allies, including, among others, the United States, France, the United Kingdom and the USSR (Union of Soviet Socialist Republics). In addition to these, several countries were present in this conflict by helping one way or another their political allies.

Millions of consequences of this event can be enumerated: the loss of innocent lives, the empowerment of certain countries such as the United Soviet Union, among others. But in this essay it will be analyzed another type of consequence, the change in the women's fashion in Italy in the periods immediately before and after World War II, including the change of materials and design of garments.

As mentioned above, this paper will focus on the materials used and women's fashion before and after World War II in Italy with the aim of answering the following question: To what extent can it be said that Italian fashion between 1929 and 1955 actually changed? To be able to tackle it in the best possible way, this question will be taken ten years before the war (1929-1939) and ten (1945-1955) after this date.

Currently, it is of huge importance to study topics related to fashion such as which is discussed in this essay as it allows to raise the chances of understanding in a better way the historical events. Fashion, clothing, art, all of them communicate aspects about society, even more, they show aspects not so visible in the written documentation and so, it is crucial to pay attention to them. A lot can be understood/deduced about how people tend to live, what customs existed, what conflicts lurked in each household, what activities were carried out. According to the historian Ramos Rodrigues, "clothing plays a communicative, symbolic and aesthetic

fundamental"(Ramos Rodrigues, 2006, p.154). In addition, any analysis of Italian fashion between 1929 and 1955 must consider how the Fascist regime attempted to construct a unified national identity through culture, industry, and everyday practices. During the ventennio, Mussolini used fashion as a political instrument to promote the idea of an “authentically Italian” style that reflected discipline, productivity, and national pride. Through institutions such as the Ente Nazionale della Moda and policies rooted in autarchy, the regime sought to standardize taste and encourage citizens to consume domestically produced goods, transforming clothing into a symbol of collective identity rather than individual expression. This cultural and ideological framework shaped the evolution of Italian fashion and left lasting effects that continued to influence the post-war industry.

It is consequential to study this subject specifically in Italy since today this country is one of the most influential for fashion, as writer Paris stands "the new capital of Italian fashion and in one of the world's leading centres alongside Paris and New York" (Paris, 2009, p.122). Italy has constituted one of the most impressive fashion centers in the world along with Paris and New York since 1951 "after the organization of the Italian Fashion Show in Florence by Giovanni Giorgini" (Paris, 2009, p.122). This does not detract from the fact that since the Renaissance, Italy has been a reference of fashion. National designers such as Mario and Miuccia Prada, Valentino Gavarani, Giorgio Armani or Donatella Versace, among others can highlight.

To be able to answer the analysis question, both primary sources will be used as secondary, which will be evaluated in order to judge their relevance in the research as well as analyzed, compared and tested for use in answer to the question. Among the sources used, it can be find, the book "Italian Fashion since 1945: A Cultural History" by Emanuela Scarpellini, as well as the article "Creativity and innovation of the Italian fashion system in the interwar period (1919-1943)." by Cinzia Capalbo. This selection of sources was written by authors who

understand the subject and with a great retrospective vision, who collaborate with general understanding of the topic. For example, Capalbo is a specialist in the subject because he is a professor in the Department of History at the Sapienza Università di Roma. Instead, Scarpellini is a historian specializing in the political and cultural history of Fascism Italian. These sources have been chosen in conjunction with others, as they have diverse perspectives on the causes of change, relevant information and data exact.

This essay will be developed in two central parts: the change that World War II brought to materials and how this affected the textile industry at the time, then the change that occurred in women's fashion.

Materials before and after the war

1929-1939

To understand why the Fascist regime later became so involved in fashion and textile production, it is key to look back at the origins of Fascism in March 1919. In that year, Milan became what many historians call the “first capital of Fascism,” where Mussolini, the founder of the Fascist regime and Italy's dictator between 1922 and 1943, founded the *Fasci di Combattimento* in which the Manifesto of Italian Combatants was published. This early program tried to bring together war veterans, soldiers, and also young men who had not fought but still felt disappointed by what they saw as a “mutilated victory,” meaning that Italy had not received the territories it had been promised after World War I. The movement presented itself as one able to restore national pride and renew Italian society. Even though the 1919 manifesto still included some democratic ideas, it already focused on discipline, collective identity, and putting the nation above the individual. These ideas later influenced Fascist cultural policies, including the effort to create an entirely Italian form of fashion based on a strict control over style, production, and materials (Franzinelli, 2019). In 1922, Benito Mussolini accessed political power and during the twenty years he was in it, he influenced almost every issue

related to politics, economy and culture. The fascist objectives of the time were reinforced by the ideals of creating a distinctly Italian textile industry, among others. Within the objectives that Mussolini had proposed for his mandate, it was the idea to create a purely Italian fashion, meaning that the materials and production needed to be originated in Italy. For this purpose, the head of Fascist regime had to have absolute control of fashion and thus a body to regulate and limit individuality within the market was created. The "*Ente Nazionale della moda Italiana*" was an institution created by the dictator to promote the development of fashion during fascism (Paulicelli, 2015). According to Giannini, it was specifically in charge of "Italianizing the women's wardrobe and adapting it to the commandments of autarchy" because Mussolini considered that a proper Italian fashion in relation to clothing, decoration and the architecture had not been achieved but could be created (Giannini, 2022).

While the country's political framework is central to the subsequent creation of Italian industry (Paulicelli, 2001), it is also possible to state that the economy of the country was the main driving force behind the subsequent development of Italian fashion (Capalbo, 2015).

According to the aforementioned author, it is possible to state this since, first of all, most Western nations eliminated free trade after the crisis economy started in 1929, which led to the limitation of international trade, leaving Italy with a great shortage of raw materials used in the textile industry. While this caused a crisis in the industry, it also led to the search for alternative materials. For this, the Italian nation started by using its own raw materials of the territory and resorting to old ones that had lost their value or had been replaced by foreign. Among these products were "orbace, wollen, hemp, mulberry and juniper." (Capalbo, 2015, p.4)

The economic crisis of 1929 gave the Fascist regime a good excuse to increase state control over the fashion and textile industries. The government presented itself as the only force able to protect the national economy, arguing that the international situation was too

unstable and that Italy could no longer depend on foreign markets. For this reason, the regime said that producing and using only national materials was a patriotic responsibility. In this context, the state began to control production, raw materials, and the organization of the textile sector (Capalbo, 2015). By promoting fibers like *lanital* and centralizing fundamental decisions, the regime tried to build a self-sufficient Italian industry, while also reducing the independence of private companies.

In contrast to the above, there are perspectives such as Claudio Belini's one, that consider the major cause of the replacement of materials Italy faced was due to the creation of artificial fibres and not because of the imports as proposed by Capalbo (2015). While both the views are noteworthy as they are current and have greater access to sources due to technology as well as a wider retrospective view, it can be said as a conclusion that Capalbo's point of view is the most accurate since Bellini describes the situation but Capalbo understands the reason behind the change of materials.

With the creation of these new fibres, many businesses emerged and flourished, including the best known, Snia-Viscosa. This company was not initially dedicated to these products but to dive into the oceans in search of raw materials for the country, but as a cause of a maritime crisis in 1920, this company began to progress with the rayon. Its growth was such that it bought and incorporated other companies such as "Rumianca, a production company for chemicals indispensable in the manufacture of artificial yarns, and in Silm, supplier of plants and machinery necessary for the production of rayon." (Capalbo, 2015, p.4). By the early 1930s, SNIA-Viscosa had extended its activities overseas and owned several companies abroad, including in the United States, reflecting its role not only as a national industrial leader but also as a player in the international textile and fiber market (Capalbo, 2015). With this new material, Italy managed, not only to stay present in the fashion industry, but also to create new fibers. The *lanital*, very similar to wool, allowed Italy to use more

domestic resources such as casein from milk but most importantly, not to have to import. By 1937, the plant Snia produced almost seven million kilos of lanital (Capalbo, 2015).

Based on the analysis that has been made up to this point, it can be said that before the outbreak of World War II, Italy was seeking to create a textile industry and thus also a fashion industry that was purely Italian. For this, national raw materials were used since the economic relations with other countries were devastated and, in addition, the socio-political context did not allow the country to import foreign raw materials. Now, can it be sure that this is going to continue after World War II or will there be any changes that break with what was established in the thirties?

From the outset, it can be said that there were some changes. At first, Italy was part of the Axis, which limited its ability to import and export goods, since it could only trade with Germany and Japan. However, after Mussolini was removed from power in 1943, Italy switched sides and joined the Allies, eventually ending the war as one of the victorious countries. This political shift opened the possibility for Italy to rebuild its economy and establish broader commercial relations with other nations.

1945-1955

Unlike 1929-1939, the post-war period led to, according to Paulicelli (2001), Italy deciding to rebuild the country that had been in the past and regain its beauty, harmony and life as well as rebuilding its identity and dignity (Paulicelli, 2001). With this in mind, Italy decided to rely on haute couture and the production of boutique fashion when exporting. This was because the country's domestic market, after the war, was not at its best time and a shortage of domestic demand became evident (Paris, 2009).

According to Scarpellini (2019), the prosperity of the textile market was due to the United States. In the post-war period, this country grew economically as it did not suffer on its territory which allowed them to become one of the biggest buyers of Italian fabrics (Motta, 2019).

Part of the Marshall Plan was intended to restore prosperity around the economic and political side of several European countries. For example, ensuring that the Italian industry was successful in addition to lending money and exporting raw materials (Garrison, 2012).

The Marshall Plan was a US program to boost the European countries during the Cold War in order to recover them from the damage caused by World War II. It is also possible to state that, according to White (2020), that this plan had ideological interests: helping European nations to distance themselves from the USSR and ensuring that communism did not expand. In relation to Italy, the Marshall objective was clear: “to strengthen Italy economically and politically so that truly democratic elements of the country can withstand the forces that threaten to sweep them with a new totalitarianism.” (U.S. Department of State, 1945, p.682). This was because the state was on the dangerous line with Communist Yugoslavia hence tending to this position, adding to the fact that the country itself was already a large communist party. It is because of this "critical" situation, from the US point of view, why Italy received a lot of economic aid (White, 2020).

As stated by the aforementioned author, the industry of Italian wool and yarn fabrics progressed and increased their production with superior quality. Thanks to the additional capital and the growth in exports supported by the Marshall Plan, the demand for raw materials rose significantly: "100,000 tonnes in 1922, 145,000 in 1940 and this figure would be equalized in 1945 having its peak in 1963 with 202000" (Scarpellini, 2019, p. 41). Cotton, however, did not experience the same proportional improvement as wool and yarn, and its moment of greater popularity and use would come later (Scarpellini, 2019).

In contrast, according to Garrison (2012), textiles managed to flourish during the post-war period because the cities that were mostly in charge of their production such as Milan, Turin or Genoa, suffered less than the cities near Rome because they were not given battles on their territory, only received bombing by the Allies. The maintenance of textile factories

allowed Italy to recover quickly after the war leaving its competitors such as Japan, the UK and France off the given radar that these three were most affected in the war (Garrison, 2012).

As a partial conclusion, it can be established that the materials were influenced by the country's political and economic situation. Before the war in question, domestic raw materials were used to develop the industry, mainly due to its few international relations to market. Instead, after the war, Italy was given the opportunity to open its international relations by being the number one economic partner of the United States, this allowed Italy to increase the materials production. Therefore, between 1929 and 1939 there was a change in the type of materials while between 1945 and 1955 there was a change in the target market.

Women's fashion before and after the war

1929-1939

Considering that the analysis of this essay starts in 1929, it is worth mentioning that the economic world crisis that began in that year produced major changes, not only in politics but also in society and therefore, also in the way of dressing. Along the previous ten years of the World War II, many women devoted their time to the house and chores of the home leaving vacant the jobs they filled during World War I for men to occupy them, so, according to Rava (2020), "*the female ideal is again showing a woman of marked sexual characters*" (Rava, 2020, p.9). The back takes center stage in night dresses for parties and for waiting for the men at home, the cleavage of the daily clothes took space. These aspects were largely influenced by Parisian fashion as well as most Italian fashion (Rava, 2020).

Italian fashion in this instance of history faced two problems: the economic crisis and the rise of Hollywood. Now, which of these problems limited in a greater scale Italian industry's growth?

First, there are experts like Rava (2020) who claim that the economic crisis determined the new fashion. Prints appeared, especially the flowery ones, and had special relevance in the thirties since they facilitate the sewing and reduce costs of fabric and allow to conceal stains, all so that people did not have to spend more than what was needed in times of crises. Moreover, the economic crisis caused high-fashion designs to highlight social differences through the expensive materials they required. "cutting at the sides requires a lot of material, the fabrics for party garments are expensive, satin, silk, lamé" (Rava, 2020, p.9). For wealthier women, fashion included embroidered details and luxurious furs, both intended to display a higher social position. In this way it can be interpreted as Rava, in which the economic crisis led to aesthetic changes for everyday fashion with the aim of using the least amount of resources possible because they were limited and also reducing the cost of production.

Despite the economic crisis faced by the country, this was not the only obstacle that prevented Italian fashion from becoming a reality. According to Ramos (2006), it was more considerable the creation of the film industry (Hollywood) in the US and its inevitably impact on fashion worldwide since the cinema was cheap and seemed luxurious: "Hollywood sells glamour for a few cents" (Rava, 2020, p.9). The famous company also offered the possibility of escaping the crisis in the country imaginatively but in turn the model Hollywood's goal was unattainable and therefore more desired by the public "were the vehicle for fantasy, the only way out of despair that dominated everyday life" (Ramos Rodrigues, 2006, p.167). In relation to women's fashion, Hollywood costumes did not predominate in the daily life of the female public but it was used a lot for night parties, evening events, and especially in luxury accessories. Therefore, Hollywood's fashion was an obstacle to the development of Italian fashion since the Italians wanted to buy what was unattainable instead of buying locally and investing in the Italian industry (Ramos Rodrigues, 2006)

According to Paulicelli (2004), the 1930s also witnessed a symbolic confrontation between the Fascist ideal of “Italianità” and the growing international appeal of American glamour. While the regime promoted a sober, disciplined, and nationally rooted aesthetic, the American company projected an image of luxury, sensuality, and modern freedom that captivated Italian audiences. Cinema offered an escapist world far removed from the economic hardships and ideological constraints of daily life, making American fashion, especially evening wear, accessories, and hairstyles, highly aspirational. As a result, Italian women were increasingly drawn to styles that contradicted the regime’s attempt to impose a uniform national identity, revealing the limits of Fascist cultural control and illustrating how global influences could subtly undermine domestic propaganda (Gundle, 2007).

Within the framework of the Second World War, Italy was affected by external circumstances but the fact that Hollywood flourished and was yearned for on a world level was what prevented to a greater extent that the fashion industry in Italy could not fully develop. This is because even though the Italians had money to invest in domestic production, they decided not to do so and buy the products from American style.

Adding more, accessories played a fundamental role in the fact that, although American fashion was beginning to take on importance through Hollywood, the Italian industry did not stop experimenting with creativity, materials, shapes and colors. An artist recognized for this development was Uberto Bonetti who was part of the futurist movement who created "definite design which became a prototype, created to be mass-produced"(Capalbo, 2016, p.8) by using raw materials such as plastic or resin. Nevertheless, the most outstanding accessories of the Italian industry of the time were the wallets/bags and the shoes that conquered the world leaving momentarily behind the popularity of Parisian fashion.

Under the analysis in question, it can be said that Italian women's fashion was conditioned by the rise of Hollywood and the ideals that cinema carries even today as well as by the world economic crisis of 1929.

1945-1955

In contrast to the time period analyzed above, the time of post-war Italian fashion would stand out for radically changing the way it is produced and therefore be used.

After the end of the war, Italian textile production was mostly orientated to the foreign market by being mainly exported to the USA due to the economic benefits mentioned above. This new market would allow Italian fashion to be much more authentic, exotic, fearless and sophisticated (Garrison, 2015). Two new ways of dressing and shopping would be developed, on the one hand, the boutique fashion and on the other hand, the ready to wear, better known as prêt-à-porter, high quality (Paulicelli, 2001). This consists of a mass production or large quantities of the same garment, partially leaving aside the haute couture that was the production of almost unrepeatable and unmatched products. This occurs mainly because for exporting it is necessary to have a rapid process and large scale production. Italian designers will have to adapt to this new way of production. For example, Elisa Massai, one of the only foreign journalists who wrote in the magazine *Women Wears Daily* invited to the Italian Fashion Show of 1951, thought that the designer Giorgini began his show with modest clothes in order to adapt to the shape of American life and way of dressing (Motta, 2019). Being a primary source counts with a great limitation that is the opinion of the author, which is limited to an interpretation of the fact, this means that it is not necessarily an absolute truth but rather an opinion or interpretation of the fact. It would not be possible to corroborate that Giorgini's objective was effectively to align with the US fashion.

In this period, Italian fashion would be recognized for its simplicity and at the same time their outstanding designs and patterns. This type of clothing would capture the attention

of American women because of how different they were, the quality that they brought with them and together with the moderate prices (Paris, 2010).

As a partial conclusion, it can be stated that there was a big change in the consumption and sales in regard to Italian women's fashion after the Second World. The need to export to the US, to improve the economy, part of its textile industry, would lead to the production of this being distinct. Before the war, the Italian fashion industry was limited by factors such as the crisis and rise of Hollywood in contrast to the postwar era in which the American aid would bring prosperity to the market.

Conclusion:

To conclude with the work done, after having analyzed two aspects of the Italian fashion, ten years before and ten years after the war, these being: materials used in the textile industry and women's fashion; it can be said that indeed, Italian fashion was re-signified and changed over the years studied.

Firstly, in relation to the materials, it is possible to state that there was an enormous change since, before the war conflict broke out, Italy tended to have a textile industry that was inefficient and in decline due to the fact that they could not import materials from foreign nations; it is, nevertheless, feasible to interpret this as a great kick for the the beginning of the development of purely Italian fashion given that the use of materials already met that factor. Once Italy broke off relations with the Axis and joined the Allies, they were able to commercialize and import materials from other countries of the world, allowing the market to expand.

Secondly, in women's fashion, it is also viable to corroborate a change because, before the Second World War, women's modes of dress tended to be recognized for being Hollywood-inspired with outstanding accessories and little national development. Moreover, after the

conflict, fashion production became more focused on mass and chain exports, which limited the originality of garments to a certain extent. By all means, it is vital to mention that with this new process of selling clothes to foreign areas, Italy managed to export its fashion.

Although both aspects have changed over the evidence, the idea put forward by Mussolini of creating a purely Italian industry based on the products, labour and national consumption, never changed.

While this essay has analyzed heterogeneous perspectives and numerous reasons to answer the research question, it is plausible to say that this answer is not necessarily the only one that can be given to it. This is because it is not possible to access all sources of information related to this topic so that all viewpoints can be considered, this provides a margin of improvement for the future. Furthermore, there are other aspects that could be taken into account such as men's fashion.

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